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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1963-1973

Coverage Date: 1963-1973

Place Coverage: Dobe Area, Botswana And Namibia

Section Title(S): LEADERSHIP • NAMED GROUPS

Table 12.4. *!Kung named groups* [Continued from previous page]

<i>Other groups not centered in one region</i>	
28. The Medicine Roots (!gwasi)	2
29. The Steenboks (/tonsi)	5
30. The Gemsboks (!gwesi)	0
31. The Jackals (/tedisi)	1
32. The Springhares (n/umsi)	3
<i>Other named groups mentioned</i>	
33. The Impalas (kxarasi)	0
34. The Cutters (/tumsi)	0
35. The Kori Bustards (!gwisi)	0
36. The Diarrheas (/gomsi)	0
37. The Kaross Knots (!gosi)	0
38. The Penises (tahsi)	0
39. The Tortoises (zimsi)	0
(n≠tobosi) ^b	0
40. The Owners of Due (Due k"xausi)	0

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LEADERSHIP

How group and individual decisions are made in a society without formal political or judicial institutions is difficult to discern. In egalitarian societies such as the !Kung's, group activities unfold, plans are made, and decisions are arrived at—all apparently without a clear focus of authority or influence. Closer examination, however, reveals that patterns of leadership do exist. When a water hole is mentioned, a group living there is often referred to by the !Kung by a single man's or woman's name: for example, Bon!a's camp at !Kangwa or Kxarun!a's camp at Bate. These individuals are often older people who have lived there the longest or who have married into the owner group, and who have some personal qualities worthy of note as a speaker, an arguer, a ritual specialist, or a hunter. In group discussions these people may speak out more than others, may be deferred to by others, and one gets the feeling that their opinions hold a bit more weight than the opinions of other discussants. Whatever their skills, !Kung leaders have no formal authority. They can  344 only persuade, but never enforce their will on others. Even the !Kung vocabulary of leadership is limited. Their word for "chief," //kaiha, derived from the word //kai ("wealth"), is applied to Bantu headmen and chiefs, and even to English kings and queens; but only rarely do the !Kung use it of other !Kung and then usually in a derisory manner. One /Xai/xai man [336] nicknamed //Kaihan!a ("Big Chief") told us it was a joking name because when he was young he tended to put on airs; people called him Big Chief to take him down a peg.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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